BEFORE THE ROOM

A Partner's Workbook for Supporting Homebirth

A GO BOIL THE WATER COMPANION

NOAH JENKS

How to Use This Book

This is your book. It goes alongside Go Boil the Water, one chapter at a time, and it's built for the guy who wants to walk into that room ready instead of guessing.

Every chapter has the same four parts.

His page is for you alone. Nobody has to read it. Write the honest answer, not the one that sounds good.

Together is for the two of you. Sit down with her, ask the questions, and write both of your answers side by side. Listen more than you talk.

Ask your midwife is a page to bring to your next prenatal visit. Ask every question out loud and write down what she says.

This week is one thing to do before you turn the page.

At the back you'll find the pages you'll use in the last few weeks before the birth, and a few more for after. Fill them in as you go. By the time labor starts, most of the thinking will already be done.

You don't have to finish the book before you start this one. If she's thirty-six weeks along and you're just now picking it up, go straight to Chapter 5 and the pages at the back. Then come back for the rest.

CHAPTER 1

Homebirth? That's a Thing?

Go Boil the Water, pages 2 to 8

The short version

When Katie first brought up home birth, I thought it was something from the 1800s, or a documentary, or something people did in a commune wearing tie-dye. I didn't say any of that out loud, which for once was the right instinct.

Here's what I didn't know. Birth happened at home for almost all of human history, and the midwife was the person the whole community leaned on. The move to the hospital came fast, mostly in the first half of the 1900s, driven by real lifesaving advances, a demand for pain relief, and the slow squeezing out of midwives. Fathers got moved out to the waiting room. When we were finally let back in, nobody gave us a job.

Home birth today has nothing to do with that pioneer-movie picture. It means a trained midwife, a safety plan, and a hospital nearby if it's needed. It's choices, not chaos.

"We got access to the room without anyone handing us a script for what to do once we were in it."

WORTH REMEMBERING FROM THIS CHAPTER

CHAPTER 1

His page

Just you. Nobody has to read this.

1 **What was your first thought when she brought up home birth? Not the diplomatic answer. The raw one.**

2 **Before you read this chapter, what did you picture when you heard "home birth"? Be specific. What's in the room? Who's there? What's going wrong?**

3 **Where did that picture come from? A movie, a story you heard, something your parents said, or nowhere in particular?**

4 **What surprised you most in this chapter?**

5 **Finish the sentence: "The thing I'm most afraid to say out loud about this is..."**

You don't have to share this page. But if one of these answers is sitting heavy, it's probably the one worth bringing to her.

CHAPTER 1

Together

Sit down with her for this one. Coffee, a walk, the couch after the kids are asleep. You each answer, and you listen more than you talk.

1 How were each of us born? Where, and who was in the room?

HIM | HER

2 When did home birth first come up for you, and what made it stick?

Her question. Your job is to ask a follow-up, not to respond.

HER ANSWER | YOUR FOLLOW-UP QUESTION

3 What's one thing each of us wants to learn more about before we decide anything?

HIM | HER

4 What did you hear from me in this conversation that you didn't expect?

HIM | HER

CHAPTER 1

Ask your midwife

Bring this page to your next visit, or to the first interview if you're still choosing a midwife.

- [ ] What's your training, and what license or certification do you hold?

- [ ] Walk me through what a home birth with you looks like, from the first call to the day after. Who comes, and what do you bring?

- [ ] If something changes during labor, how do you decide it's time to go to the hospital, and which hospital would we go to?

- [ ] Do you offer water birth? What would we need to have ready?

- [ ] Is there a class you'd recommend we take together, like hypnobirthing?

THIS WEEK

Ask your parents how you were born.

Where it happened, how long it took, and where your dad was. If he was in the waiting room, ask him what that was like.

KEEP GOING

That was Chapter 1.

There are nine more chapters, and each one works the way this one did. A page just for you, a conversation to have with her, questions to take to your midwife, and one thing to do before you turn the page.

Then come the pages you'll reach for in the last few weeks: your birth rules, who's on call, the transfer plan you hope you never use, and the golden hour. Fill them in as you go, and most of the thinking is done before labor starts.

Before the Room is made to sit right next to Go Boil the Water, one chapter at a time.

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